If consciousness did play a role in the quantum measurement process, what exactly would that mean? The most straightforward approach would be to posit a *dualist* theory of consciousness, according to which "mind" and "matter" are two distinct, interacting categories. The general idea would be that our physical bodies are made of particles with a wave function that obeys the Schrödinger equation, but that consciousness resides in a separate immaterial mind, whose influence causes wave functions to collapse upon being perceived. Dualism has waned in popularity since its heyday in the time of René Descartes. The basic conundrum is the "interaction problem": How do mind and matter interact with each other? In the present context, how is an immaterial mind, lacking extent in space and time, supposed to cause wave functions to collapse?

There is another strategy, however, that seems at once less clunky and considerably more dramatic. This is *idealism*, in the philosophical sense of the word. It doesn't mean "pursuing lofty ideals," but rather that the fundamental essence of reality is mental, rather than physical, in character. Idealism can be contrasted with physicalism or materialism, which suggest that reality is fundamentally made of physical stuff, and minds and consciousness arise out of that as collective phenomena. If physicalism claims that there is only the physical world, and dualism claims that there are both physical and mental realms, idealism claims that there is only the mental realm. (There is not a lot of support on the ground for the remaining logical possibility, that neither the physical nor the mental exists.)

For an idealist, mind comes first, and what we think of as "matter" is a reflection of our thoughts about the world. In some versions of the story, reality emerges from the collective effort of all the individual minds, whereas in others, a single concept of "the mental" underlies both individual minds and the reality they bring to be. Some of history's greatest philosophical minds, including many in various Eastern traditions but also Westerners such as Immanuel Kant, have been sympathetic to some version of idealism.

It's not hard to see how quantum mechanics and idealism might seem like a good fit. Idealism says that mind is the ultimate foundation of reality, and quantum mechanics (in its textbook formulation) says that properties like position and momentum don't exist until they are observed, presumably by someone with a mind.